

just like a human would be scared of losing his life. The accomplishment here is shown to be sentience that reaches a point where it has a sense of “life” about itself.

There’s no scientific explanation given for any of this, although the path is pretty clear. The advances in psychological understanding of the human mind develop to a point where social behaviour can be programmed into a computer, complete with subtleties. But many experts argue that the ability to program sarcasm into an intelligent agent would make it “more than human” since there are existing human beings who can’t grasp the concept of sarcasm.

KITT

Between the several bots based on the positronic brain and the HAL 9000, most concepts of science fiction were well laid down. A few glimpses of something new came through every once in a while, whose interest was mainly sparked by the practicality of their purpose. One such intelligent agent was the KITT car from the TV series *Knight Rider*.

KITT stands for Knight Industries Two Thousand, named after the company which manufactured it. Essentially, KITT is an autonomous self-driving car with personality-driven social intelligence. The “self-driving” part of the machine has been replicated to a large extent in real life today, using much of the technology that KITT used such as the frontal scanner. In this world of science fiction, the frontal scanner is able to “see” what’s coming ahead much like the human eye can and drive accordingly – a plausible explanation for how the autonomous car would work and perhaps the way self-driving cars would be engineered some day.

KITT can also “hear” and “see” all around him and inside him with the use of tiny audio-visual sensors. Funnily, the vehicle could even “smell” using some sort of an olfactory sensor.

Of course, such a simplistic explanation of optical input would require a much more complex core “brain” than anything that is currently in the realm of science. The Knight 2000 microprocessor is the centre of a “self-aware” cybernetic logic module that allows KITT to think, learn, communicate and interact with humans. It gives a male personality as well, complete with an ego and a sense of humour. According to the unofficial Knight Rider wiki, KITT’s reaction time is one nanosecond, and his memory capacity is 1,000 megabits – ridiculously low when you think about it now, but perhaps not in the context of a TV show in the early 1980s.